

What does it mean to manage \$3.2M like an investment instead of a budget?

I wasn't interested in simply spending less. I wanted every dollar to buy us more capability.

Business Results

Executive-Level Scope

Data and Measurement

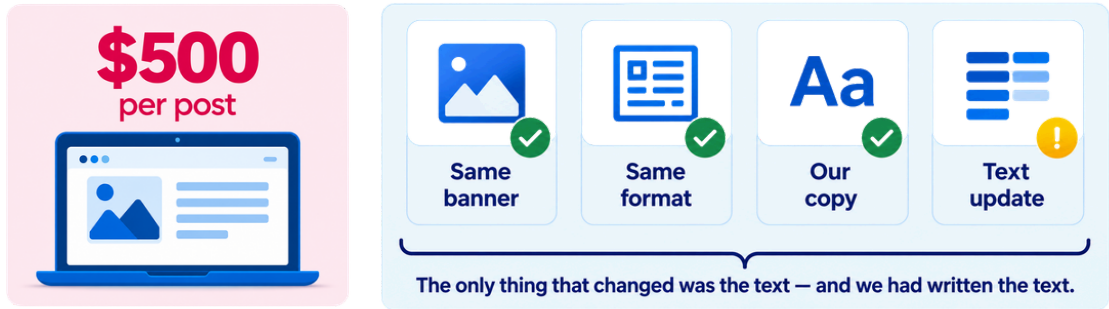
I questioned everything.

Agency rate versus contractor rate. What were we actually buying? How many hours should the work require? Why did this quote cost what it cost?

I wasn't trying to squeeze vendors for the lowest possible price. I wanted to understand what we were paying for.

Then one expense didn't match up.

A vendor charged us \$500 every time they updated a post in our digital communications app. I watched the work for a few weeks.

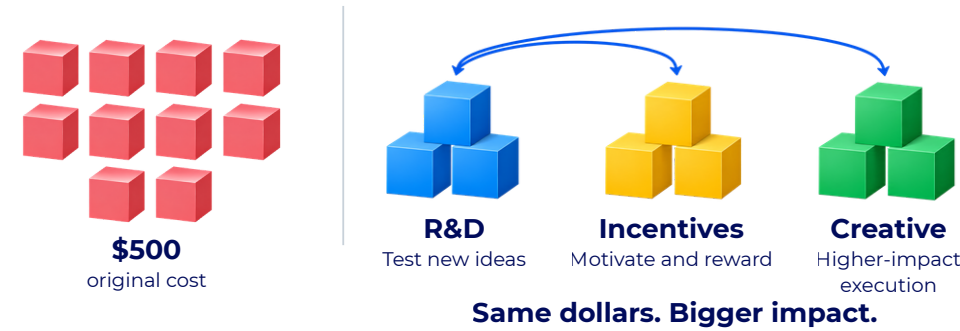


So I asked them to show me the math. What labor goes into this? How does that labor align with the hourly rates we were being charged for other assets and deliveries? As a result, they reduced the rate.



I didn't pocket the \$450.

The savings created room to invest somewhere better.



I managed the \$3.2M the same way.

Every expense was treated like an investment decision.



WHAT I'M PROUD OF

I created room to say yes. Finding efficiencies meant I could put money behind better ideas, stronger creative and experimentation instead of treating every existing expense as permanent.

MY GUIDING PRINCIPLE

Budget management is strategy. Every dollar committed to low-value work is a dollar you can't use to experiment, improve quality, or build capability.

IF I HAD A DO-OVER

I'd let my team see more of the money. I managed much of the portfolio myself, but vendor negotiations, forecasting, tradeoffs and funding decisions were leadership-development opportunities I should have shared.

AT A GLANCE



WHY THIS STORY

I want you to see how I think about resources. Constraints don't automatically make me think "cut." They make me ask where the investment is creating value — and where moving it could create more.

This story also demonstrates:

- Vendor management
- Financial stewardship
- Negotiation
- Resource allocation
- Portfolio leadership

IF WE TALK, ASK ME ABOUT

- The other vendor quotes I challenged.
- What I looked for before deciding an expense wasn't worth it.
- How I decided where recovered dollars should go.
- The hardest funding decisions I've had to make.
- A vendor negotiation that changed the relationship, not just the price.